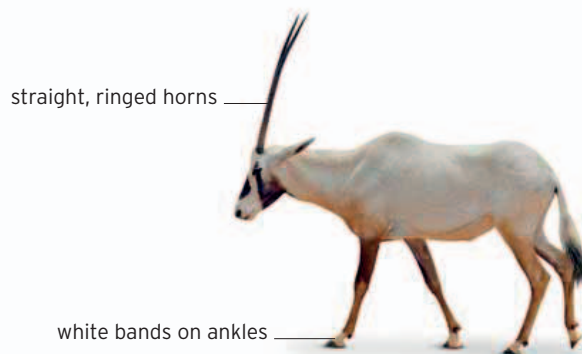




Arabian oryx

Oryx leucoryx

Few large mammals are so well adapted to survive in the extreme heat and drought of the desert as the Arabian oryx. It has wide shovel-shaped hooves for plodding great distances over loose sand. The oryx is not a great runner—its only natural predators, wolves and striped hyenas, are few in number.

The bright, almost luminous white coat helps reflect away the sun's heat, but also makes the Arabian oryx stand out against the barren landscape, even in the dark. The benefit to the antelopes of seeing their herd mates easily outweighs any risk of attracting the attention of predators. If a predator does appear on the horizon, the oryx has nowhere to hide. It takes the threat side-on, showing its full size in an attempt to deter attack.

Following the leader

An oryx herd is led by an older female and contains a few other females and their young, the dominant male, and some subordinate males. When food is plentiful after rainfall, the herd can swell into hundreds, and males defend small territories, mating with any female that comes along. In favorable conditions, females can give birth to a single calf once a year, after about 34 weeks of gestation. However, births are rare in years with low

rainfall. Outside of the breeding season, herd members are tolerant of each other, with both sexes adopting a simple hierarchy based on horn length. The lack of rivalries lets a small herd cluster in the shade of a tree during the warmest part of the day. When it is cooler, members spread out to graze, always staying within sight of each other. When it is time to move on, the lead female sets off, but stops regularly to ensure the others in her herd are following close behind.

The Arabian oryx can smell rain falling up to 50 miles (80 km) away. The herd follows the scent, covering 20 miles (30 km) in one go, mostly during the night. When they arrive, the oryxes graze on the newly sprouting desert plants. Oryxes also dig up roots and tubers using their shovel-like hooves. They can go for weeks without water, extracting the moisture they need from their food.

Operation oryx

The Arabian oryx was one of international conservation's earliest success stories. By 1972, trophy hunters had made the species extinct in the wild. By the following decade, a captive-born herd was reintroduced to a protected reserve in Oman, and they eventually spread into the wild.

Arabian oryx can **smell rain** more than **two days' walk away**

- ↔ 5–8 ft (1.5–2.4 m)
- 🏠 120–165 lb (54–75 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🌿 Grass, leaves, buds, roots
- 🏠



▷ LOCKING HORNS

Dominance is established with visual displays by individuals showing off their impressive horns. However, when the males are establishing territories, all-out fights do take place.

◁ KEEPING COOL

Young oryxes often rest near a shrub. They make a shallow pit to lie in, scraping away the hot surface sand to expose the cooler layer below.

